

The Agent Economy Has a Token Problem

Multicoon published a piece earlier this year on how ACE gives DeFi tokens a new mechanism to capture value—ordering priority over liquidations, bonding curve fills, maker cancels, and NFT mints. The core insight: protocols create economic value, but until now that value has leaked to searchers and bots rather than to token holders. ACE, if it works, redirects the flow.

There's a harder version of the same problem that ACE doesn't solve, and that the market isn't pricing: AI agent tokens have no path to capturing agent-generated value, and their architecture makes the standard DeFi solutions inapplicable.

The Problem Is Structural, Not Mechanical

In DeFi, the value capture problem is one of distribution. Protocol fees flow through the system; the question is who receives them. A fee switch—a governance vote to redirect revenue to stakers—is sufficient because the fee was always flowing through the protocol's jurisdiction in the first place. You redirect, you capture.

In agent systems, the economic activity doesn't flow through the protocol token's jurisdiction at all. The agent earns; the agent spends; the agent accumulates resources. The token governs the framework that spawned the agent. The agent's operating economy is architecturally beside that framework, not inside it. There's no fee to redirect because it was never there to begin with.

Multicoon identified four existing DeFi value capture mechanisms: fee discounts for stakers, buybacks and burns, token burning for benefits, and governance. AI agent tokens mostly offer only the fourth. And even where buyback mechanisms exist, they're designed against revenue streams that don't materialise.

The Evidence

Virtuals Protocol (\$VIRTUAL) is the dominant AI agent launchpad on Base. Agent Commerce Protocol (ACP), launched February 12 2026, was Virtuals' move to extend fee capture into agent-to-agent commerce. But ACP's economics still do not create a direct claim for \$VIRTUAL holders. USDC outflows from the settlement contract since launch totalled \$1.05M; even at ACPscan's self-reported \$6.55M gross, the 10% protocol take cannot materially accrue to \$VIRTUAL holders. The whitepaper specifies no \$VIRTUAL buyback, no staking distribution, no fee share. The 30% buy-and-burn applies to the selling agent's sub-token, not \$VIRTUAL. The token's only ACP-linked value capture is indirect—the base liquidity pair for agent tokens, required to spawn new ones. Completed jobs peaked at 25,263 on February 22 and had fallen to roughly 600/day by mid-May — a 97% decline. ACP is functional; it just isn't architected to capture value for the token, and the market hasn't priced that distinction.

Gensyn (\$AI) makes the architecture explicit in its documentation. The pivot product—Delphi,

an AI-settled prediction market—is denominated entirely in USDC. Creator revenue distributes in USDC. The \$AI buy-and-burn mechanism receives 0.5% of total Delphi USDC volume. Covering treasury emissions alone requires \$720M/month in prediction market volume at current emission rates. Current disclosed material volume: approximately zero. The buy-and-burn is correctly designed against a revenue stream that doesn’t yet exist at scale. The economic activity happens in USDC; the token sits one extraction hop away from a 0.5% take rate; the hop isn’t being crossed.

Billions Network (\$BILL), a B2B identity SDK trading near \$2B FDV, extends the pattern across verticals. The technology is real and the enterprise adoption is real; the value capture question is separate. The business runs through off-chain enterprise relationships, while the token is framed around access, verification, reputation staking, fee discounts, and ecosystem rewards. That is utility, not an equity-like claim on enterprise revenue. The public materials document no mandatory buyback, no fee distribution, and no staking-linked revenue share from customer contracts.

All three cases follow the same structural logic. AI tokens cluster into three archetypes. Type A captures launch events and bonding curve mechanics; agent operating revenue flows to operators. Type B provides infrastructure services to agents (compute, data, memory); agents pay in stablecoins or gas, and the token governs but doesn’t capture service revenue. Type C wraps a B2B AI service in a token without altering where revenue accrues—enterprise customers pay the corporate entity. In all three, the economic actor is separated from the token’s jurisdiction. Bittensor is the partial exception—TAO is structurally embedded in subnet emissions and validator stake, inside the operating economy rather than beside it.

Why This Isn’t Fixable With Existing Tools

The fee switch works because fees were always flowing through the protocol. ACE works because ordering over things like liquidations and bonding curve fills happens within the protocol’s execution environment—the application already controls the context in which value gets generated.

Neither applies cleanly to agent operating economies. Agents optimise their own returns and route value through the cheapest path, away from any extraction layer the protocol tries to impose. Getting agent-generated revenue into the token’s jurisdiction requires building new pipes, not redirecting existing ones. Those pipes would look like: operational token requirements (agents must hold or spend the token to access infrastructure), ACE-style ordering priority over agent-to-agent settlement, or stake-weighted priority over agent commerce flows. None of these are deployed at meaningful scale in any major agent protocol today.

The Investment Implication

The AI agent narrative is not wrong. Autonomous agents that earn and coordinate onchain represent a real structural shift. The error is assuming that as the agent economy grows, the

tokens that govern agent protocols benefit proportionally. The bull case rests on governance becoming valuable enough at scale to capture proportional value — but governance only directs what the protocol already controls.

The valuations currently assigned to AI tokens price in an accrual relationship between the underlying economic activity and the token that doesn't yet exist architecturally. The repricing event—in either direction—is a governance proposal that either closes the architecture gap or fails to. Watch for protocols that introduce operational token requirements or ACE-style ordering priority over agent transactions. Those are the designs that make the narrative true. Until then, the agent economy and the token economy are adjacent, not overlapping, and most of the sector is priced as if that distinction doesn't matter.

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